presented himself to the Samudrin and tried to make the best possible impression with gifts and protestations of peace. Although the Arabs did instigate some Nair guards to briefly hold Da Gama captive, he was soon freed and was heading back to Europe. Not surprisingly, he was given a hero's welcome in Lisbon. King Manuel lost no time in writing to the Spanish monarchs to inform them that the Portuguese half of the world contained India. He also assured them that India was full of Christians 'although not yet strong in faith and possessed of a thorough knowledge of it'.[8]

The Portuguese lost no time in following up on their discovery. A fleet of thirteen ships and 1200 men was dispatched under the command of Pedro Alvares Cabral. They were heavily armed with cannons and guns, still unknown in the Indian Ocean. By now the Portuguese had worked out that winds and ocean currents made it more efficient to first sail south-west and then turn east rather than hug the coast of Africa. The fleet swung so far west that they landed on the Brazil coast and claimed it for Portugal. Note that only a small part of Brazil actually fell within the Portuguese sphere as per the Treaty of Tordesillas, but cartographic ambiguity would allow the Portuguese to grab more than their share. The Spanish would have their revenge by taking the Philippines which was clearly in the Portuguese sphere. Soon, the papal division would completely break down as other Europeans joined the race.

On reaching Calicut, Cabral presented the Samudrin with many lavish gifts before putting forward the demand that he expel the Arabs and trade exclusively with the Portuguese. The Samudrin was understandably taken aback. While these negotiations were going on, a Meccan ship loaded with cargo prepared to leave for Aden. The Portuguese seized it and triggered riots in which a number of Portuguese men were killed. Cabral responded by lining up his ships and firing broadside after broadside into the city. The Samudrin was forced to flee from his palace. A number of merchant ships were seized and their sailors were burned alive in full view of the people onshore. Thus began the European domination of the Indian Ocean that would last till the middle of the twentieth century.